A CAPTIVATING LOVE STORY

UNTIL 28 OCTOBER



DEVANSHU AWASTHI

A Novel

Until 28 October

— a story of first sight —

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07 August 2022 — Jab Dil Ne Pehli Baar Dekha

— a story of first sight —

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This book is a work of personal memoir and creative non-fiction. Names, places, and specific details have been rendered as remembered and felt by the author.

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CHAPTER ONE

07 August 2022 — Jab Dil Ne Pehli Baar Dekha

Zindagi mein kuch pal aise hote hain jo na hote hue bhi hamesha ke liye yaad ban jaate hain… aur mere liye wo pal tha 07 August 2022.

Main Devanshu, class 10 ke baad class 11 mein aaya tha. Nayi coaching, nayi class, nayi zindagi… sab kuch normal tha. Physics ki coaching ka din tha. Shaam ke kareeb 4 baje main pehli baar us class mein gaya.

Mujhe nahi pata tha ki us din sirf ek class nahi, meri soch ka pura direction badalne wala hai… balki shayad meri zindagi ka definition hi badalne wala hai.

Jaise hi main andar gaya, meri nazar ek ladki par padi…

Vo nayi thi.

Patli si, simple si, aur ek alag hi innocent si khoobsurti ke saath. Usne halki peeli si dress aur jeans pehni hui thi. Uska presence loud nahi tha… par strange tarike se sab kuch usi ke aas-paas lag raha tha.

Aur phir… kuch aisa hua jo main aaj tak explain nahi kar paaya.

Aisa laga jaise waqt ruk gaya ho.

Class ki awaazein dheemi ho gayi… aur dil ne bas ek hi baat kahi—

> *“Jo guzar gaya, so guzar gaya…*
> *par jo saamne hai, wo haqiqat bhi khoobsurat hai…”*

Waqt ruk sa gaya tha

Us pal mujhe yaad hi nahi raha main kahan hoon.

Sab kuch blur ho gaya tha… sirf ek chehra clear tha.

> *“Na jaane kahan se aati hai ye kashish un chehron mein,*
> *ki dil unhe bina jaane bhi apna maan leta hai…”*

Aur sach kahu to mujhe pehli baar laga ki shayad “attraction” sirf word nahi hota… wo ek feeling hoti hai jo bina permission ke dil mein ghus jaati hai.

Dil ka ajeeb haal

Uski aankhon mein main kho sa gaya tha…

Shayad koi proper eye contact bhi nahi hua tha… par phir bhi lag raha tha jaise kuch connect ho gaya ho.

Aur usi pal ek khamosh si dua nikli:

> *“Bhagwan… agar kabhi kisi ko chahna hai, to bas isi ladki ko…”*

Aur tab mujhe Mirza Ghalib ke alfaaz jaise andar se mehsoos hue:

> *“Ishq par zor nahi hai, yeh woh aatish ‘Ghalib’*
> *jo lagaaye na lage aur bujhaaye na bane…”*
> *— Mirza Ghalib*

Main samajh nahi paaya tha… par dil samajh chuka tha.

First Sight ka asar

Class chalti rahi, par main us class mein tha hi nahi.

Har kuch seconds mein nazar khud usi taraf chali jaati thi…

Aur main khud se lad raha tha— “ye kya ho raha hai?”

Par jawab already dil de chuka tha.

> *“Kuch log sirf milte nahi…*
> *wo bina mile hi yaad ban jaate hain…”*

Aur Gulzar sahab ki tarah ek ehsaas dimaag mein aaya:

> *“Dil dhadakne ka sabab yaad aaya,*
> *wo teri yaad thi ya tera chehra…”*
> *— Gulzar*

Class khatam — aur ek nayi kahani ki shuruaat

Time ka pata hi nahi chala.

Class khatam hui.

Aur wo chali gayi…

Par jaate jaate wo mere saath chhod gayi hazaron sawaal…

Aur sabse bada sawaal— “Main usse phir kab dekhunga?”

Raat — jab khamoshi bhi bolne lagi

Ghar aa gaya… par lag raha tha main wapas hi nahi aaya.

Raat ho gayi.

Aur neend?

Woh to jaise gayab ho chuki thi.

Aankhein band karta to wahi chehra… aur aankhein kholta to bhi wahi.

> *“Neend ko aaj mujhse shikayat ho gayi,*
> *shayad use bhi pata tha…*
> *ki kisi aur ne jagah le li hai…”*

Aur kisi ne kaha tha:

> *“Mohabbat chehre se nahi hoti…*
> *magar chehra zindagi ban jata hai.”*

Ending Thought

Main us raat nahi soya…

Aur pehli baar laga ki shayad zindagi sirf jeene ke liye nahi hoti… kabhi kabhi kisi ek pal ko mehsoos karne ke liye bhi hoti hai.

Aur wo pal tha—

07 August 2022

> *“Na jaane kya likha tha us din taqdeer mein…*
> *ki ek nazar ne poori kahani likh di…”*

End of Chapter One

CHAPTER TWO

Woh Doosra Din — Chand Ka Zameen Par Utarna

Pehle din ki us mulaqat ne mere sukoon ka qatl kar diya tha. Poora din aur poori raat bas ek hi dhun dimaag mein baj rahi thi. Kitab kholta to aksharon ki jagah uski aankhein nazar aati, aur phone uthata to screen par uska chehra tasavvur (imagine) karta.

Agle din, mujhse raha nahi gaya. Main coaching ke time se aadha ghanta pehle hi wahan ja kar baith gaya. Wo kehte hain na ki “Intezaar mohabbat ki sabse khoobsurat saza hai.” Main us saza ko kaatne ke liye taiyar tha. Har aati-jaati aahat par meri nazrein darwaze ki taraf uthti, magar har baar mayusi hath lagti.

Waqt guzarta gaya, class shuru ho gayi. Teacher ne whiteboard par numericals likhne shuru kar diye, par mera dimaag to abhi bhi us darwaze ki kundi par atka tha. Wo aaj late thi.

Ek Thandi Hawa aur Uska Aana

Tabhi… achanak darwaza khula.

Maano waqt ne achanak “Slow Motion” mode on kar diya ho. Bahar se ek thandi, mehakti hui hawa ka jhonka classroom ke andar dakhil hua. Wo hawa pehle mere kaano ko chhoo kar guzri, jaise keh rahi ho— “Dekho, jiska intezaar tha, wo aa gayi.”

Darwaze par wo khadi thi. Wahi ladki, jise main pichle 24 ghanto se apne khayalon mein tarash raha tha. Magar meri imagination uske asli noor ke saamne bahut pheeki thi. Uske peeche se dhalta hua suraj apni roshni bikhair raha tha, jo uske reshmi baalon ko ek sunehri (golden) chamak de raha tha. Hawa un baalon ko itni nazakat se uda rahi thi jaise koi purani ghazal dheere suron mein baj rahi ho.

Tab mujhe Mohit Chauhan ki awaaz mein wo ehsaas yaad aaya:

> *“Kahin to hogi wo, duniya jahan tu mere saath hai…*
> *Zindagi sitaron ki, jaise koi baat hai.”*
> *— Mohit Chauhan*

Khuda Ki Fursat Ka Shahkar

Wo dheere-dheere andar aane lagi. Jab meri nazar uske chehre par padi, to aisa laga jaise khuda ne aaj chand ko aasman se be-dakhal karke zameen par bhej diya ho. Uska rang jaise dhuup mein ghuli hui chandi ho. Uske surkh gulabi hoth jaise kisi taze khile gulab ki pankhudi hon, jinpar halki si nami baaki ho.

Aur un gaalon ke paas wo ek chhota sa nishaan (birthmark)—haaye! Log ise shayad flaw kehte honge, magar mere liye wahi uski khoobsurti ka ‘Center Point’ ban gaya tha. Jaise kisi ne bahut khoobsurat shayari likh kar aakhiri mein ek chhota sa nukta (dot) laga diya ho taaki nazar na lage.

Uske kaano mein sone ki choti si baaliyan thi, jo piche se aa rahi sunlight ko qaid kar rahi thi. Jab wo chalti, to wo baaliyan aise chamakti jaise usne apni sunwayi mein do chamakte sitare taank rakhe hon. Nida Fazli sahab ka ek sher us pal mujh par bilkul sahi baith raha tha:

> *“Duniya jise kehte hain, jadoo ka khilona hai…*
> *Mil gaya toh mitti hai, kho gaya toh sona hai.”*
> *— Nida Fazli*

Magar mere liye wo sona nahi, mere dil ka sukoon ban chuki thi.

Ek Pyari Si Muskurahat

Usne ek bahut dheemi aur pyari si smile di—aisi smile jo kisi ko impress karne ke liye nahi, balki uski fitrat ka hissa thi. Us smile ko dekh kar aisa laga jaise Kailash Kher gaa rahe hon:

> *“Teri deewani… teri deewani…*
> *Ishq junoon jab hadh se badh jaaye, hanste hanste*
> *aashiq suli chadh jaaye.”*
> *— Kailash Kher*

Wo aayi aur mere thoda sa aage baith gayi. Ab whiteboard par likhe formulas mere liye sirf “kaali lakeerein” ban kar reh gaye the. Mera pura focus uski gardan par girti un baalon ki latton par tha, jinhe wo baar-bar apne kaan ke peeche karti thi.

Board Dhundhla, Wo Saaf

Har baar jab wo apna sar thoda sa jhuka kar likhti, to uske kaano ki wo baaliyan halka sa hilti, aur meri saansein wahi ruk jati. Class mein log notes likh rahe the, aur main uski sadgi ka qasida (praise) likh raha tha.

Tab mujhe Gulzar sahab ki wo lines yaad aayi:

> *“Aankhon ko vishwas nahi hai,*
> *Sapnon mein jo dekha tha, wahi hai.”*
> *— Gulzar*

Pura lecture khatam ho gaya, par mujhe physics ka ek word bhi yaad nahi raha. Class khatam hui, log apne bags utha kar jaane lage. Main wahi khada raha, us raste ko dekhta raha jahan se wo baaliyan chamakti hui bahar nikal gayi.

Mere chehre par ek ajeeb si khushi thi. Ek aisi khushi jo tab milti hai jab aapko pata chale ki aapka sapna haqiqat mein badalne wala hai. 08 August ki wo shaam, uski khushboo, wo thandi hawa aur uski wo peeli-sunehri chamak… mera Chapter 2 ab ek haseen dastaan ban chuka tha.

Ending Thought

Log kehte hain ki khuda dikhai nahi deta, magar us din us ladki ko dekh kar mujhe yakeen ho gaya ki khuda ka sabse bada karishma uski banayi hui “Khoobsurti” hai.

End of Chapter Two

CHAPTER THREE

Ek Tarfa Junoon, Insta Ki Request aur Woh Bechain Raatein

Waqt guzarta gaya, aur jo pehle din sirf ek dundhla sa attraction tha, wo ab dheere-dheere meri hons-o-hawaas par chhane wali ek aadat ban chuka tha. 07 August ke baad se Calendar ki tareekhein badal rahi thi, mausam badal rahe the, magar coaching ke us darr-o-deewar ke beech mera haal bilkul nahi badla tha.

Ab meri zindagi ka ek hi fixed schedule ban chuka tha—coaching ke time se theek aadha ghanta pehle pahunchna, corridor ke us purane bench par baith kar us darwaze ko takte rehna, aur jaise hi hawa mein uske baalon ki khushboo ghule aur uske kaano ki baaliyan chamakti hui andar aayein, mere chehre par ek andekhi, ankahi si smile ka khud-ba-khud tair jaana. Wo smile aisi thi jise agar main chah kar bhi chhupana chahta, toh dil baghavat kar deta tha.

Woh ladki bilkul anjaan thi is baat se ki koi ladka uske ek baar palkein jhukane par apni poori kayenaat waar dene ke

liye taiyar baitha hai. Uss pal dimaag mein KK ka wo haseen ehsaas kisi sargarmi ki tarah gunjta tha:

> *“Dil ibadat kar raha hai, dhadkanein meri sun…*
> *Tujhko main rakh loon wahan, jahan pe kahin hai mera sukoon.”*
> *— KK*

Lecture Blur, Sirf Woh Clear

Classroom ke andar ka nazaara dekhne layak hota tha. Teacher whiteboard par Physics ke lambe-lambe numericals aur complex derivations likh rahe hote, unki awaaz poore kamre mein goonjti, magar mere liye wo sab ek be-maani shor tha. Maano meri aankhon par kisi ne ek “Gaussian Blur” ka filter laga diya ho, jahan aane-jaane wale log, udti hui chalk ki dhool, aur deewaron par tange charts sab dhundhle the. Is poori bheed mein agar kuch “Ultra HD” mein bilkul saaf aur sunehra dikhayi deta tha, toh woh sirf uska chehra, uske gaal ka wo chhota sa nishaan, aur uski masoomiyat thi. Pura lecture bas use door se niharne mein hi nikal jata.

Famous poet John Keats ki ek kitabi line mere dil ke panno par baar-baar khulti thi:

> *“A thing of beauty is a joy forever…”*
> *— John Keats*

Aur mere liye wo joy, wo sukoon sirf woh thi. Tab mujhe Tehzeeb Hafi sahab ka ek bada hi mashhoor khayal yaad aata tha jo meri is khamoshi par bilkul fit baithta tha:

> *“Tera chup rehna mere zehen mein kya baith gaya,*
> *Itni awaazein tujhe di ki mera gala baith gaya.”*
> *— Tehzeeb Hafi*

Magar afsos, meri awaaz toh mere halq se bahar nikalne ki himmat hi nahi kar pa rahi thi. Main andar hi andar ek imaginary duniya bana chuka tha, jahan main usse dheron baatein karta, usse sawal puchta aur uski taraf se ek pyara sa jawab soch kar khud hi sharma jata.

Coaching Se Ghar Tak Ka Safar

Jab class khatam hoti aur wo apna bag kandhe par taang kar, doston ke beech hansti hui bahar nikalti, toh mera ek alag hi imtihan shuru hota tha. Main jaan-boojh kar apna bag dheere-dheere pack karta taaki wo aage nikal jaye, aur main uske peeche-peeche chal saku. Usse door se chalte hue

dekhna bhi ek sukoon tha.

Ghar lautne ka wo rasta jo mushkil se das minute ka tha, ab mujhe ghanton ka lagne laga tha. Mera dimaag coaching room mein hi chhoot jata tha. Cycle chalate hue ya paidal chalte hue, hawa ka har jhonka mujhe wahi lagta jo class mein uske aane par chala tha. Main raaste mein khud se hi baatein karta—“Devanshu, tu bas ek baar uske samne ja kar khada kyun nahi ho jata? Ek baar usse bahaane se hi sahi, physics ki kisi book ka naam kyun nahi puch leta?” Par dil ka darr aur dimaag ki sharafat mujhe hamesha rok leti.

Mujhe Waseem Barelvi sahab ka ek bada hi pyara sher yaad aata tha:

> *“Kaun si baat kahan, kaise kahi jaati hai,*
> *Yeh salika ho toh har baat suni jaati hai.”*
> *— Waseem Barelvi*

Aur mujhe lagta tha ki abhi mujhme wo salika, wo himmat aayi hi nahi hai.

Operation: Instagram ID

Jab dil ka sabra tootne laga aur ye bechaini hadd se badhne lagi, toh maine doston ke zariye ek silsila shuru

kiya—‘Operation Instagram’. Yeh itna aasaan nahi tha. Agar main doston se direct bolta, toh wo poori coaching mein dhandora peet dete aur mera mazaak banate. Isliye maine ek chalaki ki. Ek din break mein maine doston ke sath baith kar aisi baatein shuru ki jaise main coaching ke saare bachhon ki profiles dhoondh raha hoon. Baaton-baaton mein maine ek dost ke phone mein uski class ke batch ki list dekhi. Aakhirkar, ek shaam ek dost ne bade khufiya tarike se mujhe uski Instagram ID dhoondh kar de hi di.

ID screen par thi. Uska naam aur uski wo dundhli si round profile picture mere samne chamak rahi thi. Magar… “Follow Request” ka wo blue button dabane ki himmat kahan se lata? Wo chhota sa blue button us waqt mujhe kisi Himalaya parvat jaisa bhaari lag raha tha. Kayi dino tak roz raat ko, jab poora shehar so jata tha, main apne kamre ki light band karke uski profile khol kar baithta tha.

Jab uski profile picture mere mobile ki screen par hoti thi, toh aisa lagta nahi tha ki ye koi digital photo hai. Aisa lagta tha jaise samne kisi ne khuda ke haathon se tarashi hui ek behad naayab aur muqaddas (pure) moorat rakh di ho. Aisa lagta tha jaise khuda ne khud bade niyam se, uske saare angles ko set karke, bade itminaan se uski wo ek tasveer nikali ho taaki duniya ko apni kaarigari dikha sake. Us dundhli si choti picture mein bhi uska jo noor tha, wo mere poore andhere kamre ko roshan karne ke liye kaafi tha. Main screenshot lekar, use zoom kar-kar ke ghanton dekhta rehta.

Uski aankhon ki gehrai mein mujhe apna aane wala kal dikhta tha.

Amrita Pritam ki kitabon mein jise ‘Khaamoshi ka darr’ kehte hain, wo mujhe mehsoos ho raha tha. Darr lagta tha ki kahin galti se koi puraani photo double-tap na ho jaye aur mera ye silsila shuru hone se pehle hi khatam na ho jaye.

> *“Ghalib ne kaha tha kabhi ki ‘in jheel si aankhon mein kho jana laazmi hai’,*
> *Maine toh bas ek tasveer dekhi aur hosh gawa baitha.”*

Phir ek raat, 07 August ki us tishnagi ko yaad karte hue, dil ne dimaag ki ek nahi suni. Maine ek gehri saans li, darr ke maare kapkapate haath se mobile pakda, aankhein band ki, aur ‘Request Bhej Di’.

The Blue Tick Anxiety aur Raaton Ki Tanhai

Request bhejne ke agle hi pal jo roller-coaster shuru hua, wo dimaag ko pagal karne ke liye kaafi tha. Seene mein ek ajeeb si thandak aur bechaini dono ek sath utar gayi thi. Har do-do minute mein phone uthana, screen ko baar-bar refresh karna, notification panel ko upar-neeche scroll karna—ye meri roz ki bimari ban gayi thi.

Kai din beet gaye, phir kai hafte… wo request pending ki pending hi rahi. Meri halat aisi ho gayi thi jaise Piyush Mishra ki lines mein hoti hai:

> *"Duniya ke niyam se chalta hoon, par andar ek toofan hai,*
> *Main jo dikhta hoon wo hoon nahi, meri alag hi ek dastaan hai."*
> *— Piyush Mishra*

Har subah coaching mein jab main use dekhta, toh dil zor se dhadakta. Lagta ki kya isne meri request dekh li hogi? Kya ye mujhe koi stalker samajh rahi hai? Jab wo class mein apni saheliyon ke sath baith kar hasti ya phone chala rahi hoti, toh mera dimaag chalne lagta—"Kya ye abhi meri hi request dekh kar mazaak uda rahi hai?" Darr aur umeed ke beech dil aise jhul raha tha jaise koi doli toofan mein phansi ho. Raat ko neend aati nahi thi, aur subah ka silsila khatam nahi hota tha.

Woh Haseen Vardaan

Magar phir, ek naseeb wali shaam ko jab main bilkul umeed kho chuka tha, main apne kamre mein baith kar physics ke boring notes bana raha tha. Mera phone table par

rakha tha aur achanak wo ek lambi vibration ke sath roshan hua. Maine bina kisi umeed ke screen par nazar daali… aur wahan jo likha tha, usne mere hath se pen gira diya. Screen par chamak raha tha— ‘accepted your follow request’.

Wo pal… Devanshu ki zindagi ka wo sabse bada ‘Vardaan’ tha. Aisa laga jaise khud bhagwan ne aasmaan se haath rakh kar mujhse kaha ho— “Ja Devanshu, dekh meri banayi hui ye naayab cheez kitni khoobsurat hai, maine tujhe iski duniya mein dakhila de diya.”

Meri khushi ka koi thikana nahi tha. Main apne bistar par khada ho gaya, dil itni zor se dhadak raha tha jaise seene se bahar nikal aayega. Aisa lag raha tha jaise main zameen par nahi, badalon par chal raha hoon. Background mein maano Nusrat Fateh Ali Khan sahab ki wo qawwali goonj uthi ho:

> *“Tumhein dillagi bhool jaani padegi…*
> *Mohabbat ki raahon mein aa kar to dekho.”*
> *— Nusrat Fateh Ali Khan*

ID Scroll Karne Ka Silsila aur Woh Adhoore Khat

Ab mera ek naya marz shuru ho chuka tha. Mujhe ab kisi physics ke tuition ki, kisi lecture ki parwah nahi thi. Mera

saara din, saari raat bas uski ID scroll karne mein nikal jata. Uske posts, uski highlights, uski purani photos… bas unhe baar-baar dekhna. Ek-ek photo par ja kar main un panno ki tarah use padhta tha jaise koi naya novel padh raha hoon. Un photos mein uski aankhon ki chamak, uske baalon ka dhang, aur uski smile ko dekh kar main ghanton akele baith kar muskura sakta tha. Mujhe uski pasand-na-pasand ka andaza uski posts se hone laga tha.

Magar ye rollercoaster ab ek naye mod par tha. Request accept ho gayi thi, main uski digital life ka hissa ban chuka tha, par DM (Direct Message) karne ki himmat abhi bhi zero thi.

Har raat main chat box kholta tha. Keyboard par ‘Hi… Hello… Devanshu here…’ type karta. Ungliyan ‘Send’ ke button par ja kar thar-thar kaanpne lagti thin. Ek ajeeb sa darr dimaag mein chha jata—Kahin wo bura na maan jaye? Kahin wo mujhe block na kar de? Agar usne kal coaching mein mujhe dekh kar muh fer liya toh? Aur phir main un saare lafzon ko backspace daba kar erase kar deta. Chat box wapas khaali ho jata, bilkul meri tarah.

Jaun Elia sahab ka wo panna mere dil par har raat khul jata tha:

> *“Ye mujhe chain kyun nahi padta,*
> *Ek hi shakhs tha jahan mein kya?”*
> *— Jaun Elia*

Aur Arijit Singh ke gaane ki ye lines hamesha mere headphone mein aur mere dil mein background music ki tarah chalti rehti:

> *“Khairiyat pucho, kabhi kaifiyat pucho…*
> *Tumhare bin deewane ka kya haal hai.”*
> *— Arijit Singh*

Waqt apni raftaar se nikalta chala gaya. Mera ye ek-tarfa ishq ab instagram ke un digital panno aur coaching ke un benches ke beech qaid tha. Subah coaching mein use door se dekhna, uske aane par ek ankahi smile dena, aur raat ko uski ID scroll karte hue adhoore messages chhod dena—yehi meri poori dastaan ban chuki thi. Himmat nahi thi message karne ki, par dil mein umeed ki ek choti si kiran ab pehle se zyada roshan thi. Main is adhoorepan mein bhi ek alag hi nasha mehsoos kar raha tha.

Ending Thought

Zindagi mein kabhi-kabhi kisi ko paana ya usse baat karna hi sab kuch nahi hota. Kisi ke intezaar mein bechain hona, uski ek accepted request ko bhagwan ka inaam samajhna, aur uske naam ke notification se dil ka dhadak jaana—ye ehsaas bhi kisi jannat se kam nahi hota. Main us jannat mein jee raha tha, aur meri us jannat ka naam sirf ‘Woh’ thi. Ab agla kadam kya hoga, ye mujhe bhi nahi pata tha, par dil ab rukne ke mood mein nahi tha.

End of Chapter Three

CHAPTER FOUR

Woh Ek DM, Adhoora Intezaar aur Ek Anokha Rishta

Raat Ka Sannaata Aur Woh Ek Blue Button

Instagram par follow request accept hona mere liye kisi khuda ke vardaan se kam nahi tha, magar ye toh us bade toofan ke aane se pehle ka sannaata tha jo mere andar utarne wala tha. Request accept kya hui, maano mujhe apni jannat ka ek chhota sa chorr mil gaya tha. Magar digital duniya ka ek dastoor hai—dakhila mil jaane se rishte nahi ban jaate.

Ek raat, jab poora shehar so chuka tha, gali ke kutte tak khamosh the, aur mere kamre mein sirf mere mobile ki roshni chamak rahi thi, dimaag ki saari deewaron ko tod kar dil ne ek ajeeb si himmat ki. Maine darr se kaanpte hue anguthe se chat box khola. Wahan blank screen par uska naam likha tha. Maine keyboard par ungliyan rakhin. Pehle ‘Hello’ type kiya, phir use erase kiya. Phir ‘Hey’ type kiya, use bhi erase kiya. Aakhirkar, maine sirf do lafzon ka ek

chhota sa masoom paigham bheja— ‘Hi…’.

Bhejne ko toh bhej diya, par uske baad jo hua, wo kisi lambi saza se kam nahi tha. Din beete, hafte beete, magar wahan koi reply nahi aaya. Wo ‘Hi’ wahan ek tarfa sawal ban kar khada raha. Har do minute mein phone uthana, chat box check karna aur wahan sirf ‘Sent’ dekhna dil ko andar tak chhil deta tha. Padhne walon ne aksar kitabon mein suna hoga ki intezaar meetha hota hai, par us digital door mein wo bina khula hua inbox ek ajeeb sa zeher ugalta tha. Har guzarta din mujhe Bashir Badr sahab ke is khayal ke qareeb la raha tha:

> *“Koi haath bhi na milaeyga jo galey milo ge tapaak se,*
> *Yeh naye mizaaj ka shehar hai, zara faasle se mila karo.”*
> *— Bashir Badr*

Wallpaper Ka Noor Aur Dil Ki Zidd

Main haar manne walon mein se nahi tha. Jab reply nahi aaya, toh dil ne ek naya bahaana dhoondha. Maine uski ID se uski sabse masoom tasveer nikali, jisme usne halki si muskurahat ke sath apne kaano ki baaliyon ko chhupa rakha tha, aur use apne mobile ka wallpaper bana liya. Ab

programming aur coding ke naye panno ke beech jab bhi phone unlock hota, sabse pehle us khuda ki tarashi hui moorat ka deedar hota. Dimaag mein Arijit Singh ka wo dard goonjta tha:

> *“Humdard hai, humdum hai, tu hi mera sukoon…*
> *Tujhe paane ka hi ab dil mein hai junoon.”*
> *— Arijit Singh*

Roz raat ko us wallpaper ko dekh kar main khud se baatein karta. Main sochta ki ek din jab humari baat hogi, toh main use bataunga ki kaise main uski ek tasveer ke sahare poori raat kaat leta tha. Par woh in sab baaton se, is pure junoon se bilkul bekhabar thi.

Class 11 Ka Ikhtetaam (The Final Lectures)

Waqt ka pahiya apni raftaar se chalta raha. Class mein door se use dekh kar ek andekhi smile de dena, uski un sone ki baaliyon ki chamak ko whiteboard par chalte chalk se zyada dhyan se dekhna, aur dimaag mein bas yahi khayal rakhna ki—kaash, kaash kabhi humari baatein shuru ho sakein.

Isi kashmakash mein padhai bhi chalti rahi aur dimaag ka toofan bhi. Jab teacher physics ke bade numericals solve

karwate, toh mera dimaag bas uski taraf ghuma rehta tha. Pata hi nahi chala kab Class 11 poori tarah khatam ho gayi aur coaching mein garmiyon ki chhuttiyon ka ailan ho gaya. Sab bachhe khush the ki ab subah jaldi nahi uthna padega, par mere liye wo ailan kisi qayaamat se kam nahi tha.

Sookhi Hui Garmiyon Ki Chhuttiyaan

Chhuttiyaan… jo baaki bachhon ke liye sukoon lati hain, mere liye ek lambi saza ban gayi thin. Ab na toh main roz subah jaldi uth kar coaching ke corridor mein uske aane ka intezaar kar sakta tha, na uski reshmi baalon se udti hui hawa ko mehsoos kar sakta tha, aur na hi uski wo dheemi si awaaz sun sakta tha.

Gulzar sahab ki wo nazm jaise mere kamre ki khamoshi ban gayi thi:

> *“Khuda hafiz kehne ka salika toh seekh liya humne,*
> *Magar unke bina jeene ka tarika ab tak nahi aaya.”*
> *— Gulzar*

Tanhai itni badh gayi ki uski ID stalk karte-karte wo purani photos bhi kam padne lagin. Ab naye posts nahi aate the, aur main unhi purani tasveeron ko dekh-deekh kar waqt kaat raha tha. Mera dil us khali chat box ki tarah bilkul soona

pad gaya tha.

16 July: Ek Naye Rishte Ka Aaghaaz

Andheri raaton ke baad hi ek haseen subah hoti hai, aur meri is sookhi hui dastan mein ek naye kirdar ki entry hui—16 July.

Yeh wo din tha jab meri zindagi mein ek aisi ladki aayi jo usi ke school mein padhti thi. Woh koi aur nahi, balki meri us ‘chahat’ ki sabse pakki saheli, uski best friend thi. Shuruat mein toh sab formal tha, par dosto, kudrat ke khel bhi ajeeb hote hain. Dheere-dheere humare beech ek behad paak, pyara aur masoom sa bhai-behen ka rishta ban gaya. Wo mujhe apna saga bhai manne lagi, aur main use apni choti behen jise khuda ne mere is akelepan ko door karne ke liye bheja tha.

Raaz Ka Khulna Aur Farishtey Ki Fikr

Us behen ka nature itna caring aur pyara tha ki usne aate hi meri khamoshiyo ko padhna shuru kar diya. Jab ignore hona meri aadat ban chuka tha, tab usne mere dil ki shiddat ko dekha. Javed Akhtar sahab ki ek line us behen ke caring nature par bilkul sahi baithti hai:

> *“Rishte wo nahi jismein rooz baat ho,*
> *Rishte wo hain jahan doori chahe jitni ho, par dil mein fikar sath ho.”*
> *— Javed Akhtar*

Usne mujhse kaha, “Bhai, tu chinta mat kar. Main hoon na. Terii ye shiddat zaye (waste) nahi jayegi.”

Behen Ka Pyaar Aur Woh Haseen Dilaasa

Wo ladki jitni meri chahat ki dost thi, usse kahin zyada meri parwah karne wali behen ban gayi thi. Jab bhi main udaas hota ki ‘wo reply nahi karti’, wo behen mere sar par haath rakh kar kehti— “Bhai, pareshan mat ho, wo thodi aisi hi hai… par tera dil bohot saaf hai, wo ek din zaroor samjhegi.”

Uska wo dilaasa mere liye kisi thandi hawa ke jhonke jaisa hota tha. Jab wo dekhti ki main phone haath mein liye uski ID dekh raha hoon, toh wo bade pyaar se phone chheen leti aur kehti, “Bhai, thoda sabra rakh, jo tera hai wo tere paas zaroor aayega.”

Classroom Ka Rang Aur Nok-Jhok

Class 12 shuru ho chuki thi aur hum teeno ek hi coaching ke batch mein the. Ab mazaak, emotions aur drama double ho chuka tha. Jab bhi main us behen ke saamne baithta, toh mera ek hi kaam hota—bas din bhar kuch na kuch bolte rehna. Main uski bench ke paas baith jata aur ghanton us ladki ki pyari-pyari baatein karta rehna. “Bhai, pata hai aaj usne baal khule rakhhe the…”, “Bhai, aaj wo jab hans rahi thi toh kitni masoom lag rahi ti…” Meri behen meri in baaton ko bade dhyan se sunti, kabhi-kabhi haath par dheere se maarti aur hasti.

Class chal rahi hoti, teacher serious hokar board par physics ke bade rule likh rahe hote, aur wo behen achanak mere peeche wali bench se thoda aage jhukti aur mere kaan mein dheere se phusphusati— “Bhai, dekh… wo dekh teri taraf dekh rhi hai! Aise mat baith, thoda hero ban ke baith!” Main ghabra kar jab darwaze ya whiteboard ki taraf dekhne lagta, toh wo peeche se apne muha par haath rakh kar dheere se hasti aur kehti— “Pappu paas ho gaya! Bhai, tu toh sach mein sharma gaya!”

“Dil Ka Kya Kare Sahab…” Aur Jhooti Hope

Kabhi-kabhi jab wo ladki class mein dakhil hoti, apni peeli dress aur sone ki baaliyan pehne hue, toh wo behen mere kandhe par dheere se thapki maarti aur muskurakar ek

aisi baat keh deti jo seedhe rooh tak jaati. Woh dheere se mere kaan mein kehti:

> *“Dil ka kya kare sahab…*
> *tum unhi pe marte hai.”*

Main jab sharma kar reh jata, toh wo behen mujhe ek meethi, pyaari aur jhooti si hope deti thi. Woh har roz mujhe ek nayi umeed ke sahare jeena sikhati. Woh kehti, “Bhai, tu dekhna… ek din wo teri is sachi mohabbat ko zaroor samjhegi. Wo ek din khud aakar tujhse baat karegi, wo maan jayegi bhai, tu bas apna dil chhota mat kar.”

Mujhe dimaag ke kisi kone mein pata tha ki shayad wo mujhe khush dekhne ke liye, mera hausla badhane ke liye ye jhoot bol rahi hai, par us jhooti umeed mein bhi jo sukoon tha, wo kisi asli vardan se kam nahi tha. Main us umeed ke nashe mein roz jhoomta. Aisa lagta tha jaise Jaun Elia ka koi adhoora panna mere samne khul gaya ho:

> *“Jo guzar rahi hai hum par, kya usse bayaan karein,*
> *Bas yun samajh lo ki dil hi toh hai jo unpar haar baithe hain.”*
> *— Jaun Elia*

Aate-Jaate Raaste Aur Toofan Se Pehle Ka Sannaata

Isi hansi-mazaak, taang-khichai, aur behen ke us pyaare mazaak ke beech Class 12 ke din bade khubsoorat kat rahe the. Subah coaching aana, raste mein door se uski ek jhalak dekh lena, aur raste mein aate-jaate us behen ka peeche se achanak chadhana aur kehna—“Bhai, dekh bhabhi ja rahi hai, thoda slow chala cycle!”—ye sab meri zindagi ka sabse haseen aur yaadgar daur ban chuka tha. Main us behen ki di hui jhooti hope ke sahare roz khwaab bunta tha ki ek din hum teeno sath baithkar hansi-mazaak karenge.

Main us nashe mein itna doob chuka tha ki mujhe lagne laga tha ki kismat ab mere sath hai aur sab kuch thik ho jayega. Magar kismat ke panno par toh kuch aur hi gehra likha tha. Zindagi jab aapko sabse zyada khush karti hai, tabhi wo sabse bada aur un-expected jhatka deti hai. Aise hi haste-muskurate aate-jaate rasto ke beech, ab coaching mein kuch aisa hone wala tha jiski umeed na mujhe thi, na meri us pyari behen ko, aur na hi batch ke kisi aur bachhe ko. Ek aisa toofan jo hum teeno ke is masoom rishte aur meri is ek-tarfa dastan ko hamesha ke liye palatne wala tha…

End of Chapter Four

CHAPTER FIVE

Water Park Ka Trip, Bheegi Hui Baaliyan Aur Woh Pehla Lams

Unexpected Surprise Aur Dimaag Mein Chalti Nayi Movie

Class 12 ki padhai apni wahi purani, ubaao raftaar se chal rahi thi. Whiteboard par Physics ke derivatives, D-block ke elements, aur integration ke formulas… dimaag par bojh ban kar gir rahe the. Hum sab bas isi koshish mein the ki kisi tarah ye lectures khatam hon. Magar ek din, coaching ke sir ne class ke beech mein achanak ek aisi announcement ki jiski kisi ko door-door tak umeed nahi thi.

Sir ne smile karte hue kaha— “Bachho, padhai bohot ho gayi, is Sunday humara poora batch ek din ke trip par Water Park ja raha hai!”

Wo ailan sunte hi poore classroom mein ek shor gunguna utha. Sab bachhe taaliyan bajane lage, par mere andar toh

maano kisi ne ek nayi romantic movie ka plot chala diya ho. Sir ke shabdh mere dimaag mein slow-motion mein repeat hone lage. Maine turant peeche mud kar us behen ki taraf dekha, uske chehre par ek shaitani muskaan thi, aur uske aage baithi thi—Woh.

Bus, us din ke baad se mera ek hi kaam tha—daily calendar ki tareekhein kaatna aur bas us Sunday ka intezaar karna. Din itne dheere beete jaise koi adhoori ghazal ruk-ruk kar baj rahi ho. Nida Fazli sahab ki ye lines mere dimaag mein goonjti thin:

> *“Har taraf har jagah beshumar aadmi,*
> *Phir bhi tanhaiyon ka shikar aadmi.”*
> *— Nida Fazli*

Magar us tanhai mein ab us trip ka ek roshan chirag jal chuka tha.

Car Ka Safar: Honthon Par Zulfen, Hari Nas Aur Kumar Vishwas Ka Noor

Aakhirkar wo haseen subah aa hi gayi. Shehar par abhi halki si dhoop utar rahi thi jab hum sab water park ke liye nikalne lage. Ye meri zindagi ka pehla aisa din hone wala tha jab main poore 12 ghante, bina kisi lecture ke darr ke, sirf

aur sirf use dekh sakta tha.

Kismat ne us din pehla patta mere haq mein pheka. Hum sab log car mein baithe, aur woh bilkul mere aage wali seat par aakar baith gayi.

Car aage badhi, aur mera safar shuru hua. Main seat ke beech ke gap se uska side profile dekh raha tha. Khidki se aati hui thandi hawa uske baalon ki un halki-halki zulfon ko aakar uske gulabi honthon par bikhra rahi thi. Wo baar-baar un zulfon ko apne honthon se hatane ki koshish karti, aur wo hawa unhein wapas uske chehre par gira deti.

Phir achanak, usne apne nazuk, gore haathon se un baalon ko samet kar peeche kiya… aur jaise hi usne baal peeche kiye, uske gale par chamakti hui wo halki hari-hari si nas dikhayi di. Uski side se dikhti hui wo lambi, jhuki hui palke, wo masoom sa kaan, aur wo surahi jaisi gardan… aisa lag raha tha jaise khuda ne fursat ke kisi behad muqaddas lamhe mein uske saare ang khud apne haathon se tarashe hon.

Uss pal Dr. Kumar Vishwas ki wo mashhoor panktiyan mere dil ki dhadkan ban kar bajne lagin:

> *“Swayam Bhagwan ne fursat mein tera roop dhaarha hai,*
> *Tujhe banakar khuda ne bhi apna dil haara hai…*
> *Koi Deewana Kehta Hai, Koi Pagal Samjhata Hai,*
> *Magar Dharti Ki Bechaini Ko Bas Badal Samjhata Hai!”*
> *— Kumar Vishwas*

Us masoom chehre ko dekh kar Zakir Khan ka wo raw aur jazbaati andaaz mere dimaag mein goonj utha:

> *“Kamal toh ye hai ki hume unke har roop se muhabbat hai,*
> *Magar jab wo zulfen peeche karti hain, toh lagta hai jaise qayamat aane wali hai.”*
> *— Zakir Khan*

Us din uske baalon se ek aisi pyari, mithi si khushboo aa rahi thi jo aaj itne saalon baad bhi mere zehen mein mehfooz hai. Us pal mere andar Punjabi geet ki mithaas behne lagi:

“Tere mukhde te til kaala, ni saanu maareya is adaa ne…
Zulfaan de jaal vich aake, asaan taan dil har baite.”
“Kije koi majboor, kije koi laachar…
Yeh ishq nahi aasaan, bas itna samajh lijiye.”

Us chehre aur gale ki us hari nas ko dekhte-dekhte poora rasta kab kat gaya, pata hi nahi chala. Car ruki aur samne water park ka board chamak raha tha.

The Danger Slide Aur Swarg Ka Eye-Contact

Water park mein dakhil hote hi har taraf paani ka shor aur logo ki hansi goonj rahi thi. Pehle toh sab alag-alag rides par gaye, par asli magic tab hua jab hum us park ki sabse khatarnaak tube-slide ke paas pahunche.

Wahan hum chaar log the—main, meri behen, mera dost, aur woh.

4-seater tube slider par jab hum baithe, toh kismat ne phir ek khel racha. Woh bilkul mere samne wali seat par baithi thi. Tube slide ke andar chali, paani ke tez jhonke hum par girne lage, aur tube gol-gol ghoomne lagi. Us slide ke andhere aur paani ke beech humare beech jo eye-contact hua, wo bayaan se bahar tha. Paani ki boondein uske chehre

par tapak rahi thin, uski baaliyan bheeg chuki thin, aur wo darr ke maare muskurate hue seedhe meri aankhon mein dekh rahi thi. Uss pal mujhe laga ki main zameen par nahi, kisi swarg mein hoon.

Jubin Nautiyal aur Arijit Singh ke gaano ki mithaas mere dimaag mein gunj rahi thi:

> *“Aankhon mein teri ajab si, ajab si adaayein hain…*
> *Dil ko bana de jo patang, saanson mein teri woh hawaayein hain.”*
> *— Jubin Nautiyal & Arijit Singh*

Aur Satinder Sartaaj ka wo Sufi ehsaas mere andar beh raha tha:

> *“Uddan doriyaan, amberan de naal jee…*
> *Saiyan saade dil nu tu sajjna sambhaal jee…”*
> *— Satinder Sartaaj*

Behen Ka Masterplan Aur Woh Pehla Lams (First Touch)

Tukur-tukur use dekhne ka ye silsila meri behen ne pakad liya. Usne meri aankhon mein chhupe us junoon ko

padh liya aur mere paas aakar ek halki si chutki kaat kar boli— “Bhai, bohot swarg ke maze le liye, ab chal ek asli ride par tujhe uske sath bithati hoon!”

Meri behen ne turant ek alag aur behad adventurous 2-seater raft ride dhoondhi. Usne jaakar us ladki se baat ki, use thoda manaaya, aur aakhirkar wo ride ke liye maan gayi.

Jab hum dono us ride par baithne lage, toh mera dil 200 ki speed se dhadak raha tha. Paani ke tez bahaao ke beech tube balance karne ke liye hume ek doosre ki raft ki handles ya haath pakadne the. Aur tab hua wo miracle—pehli baar mere haath uske bheoge hue, nazuk haathon ko chhoo rahe the.

Wo touch… wo pehla lams itna paak aur itna gehra tha ki mere seene mein ek bijli si daud gayi. Paani ke thande chhit’te hum par gir rahe the, par mera jism aag ki tarah garam tha. Main andar hi andar dua kar raha tha ki—Hey bhagwan, ye ride kabhi khatam hi na ho. Ye paani ka bahaao aisa hi chalta rahe aur ye din yahi thahar jaye.

Manhar Seth ki lines aur Jaun Elia ka andaaz us pal par bilkul fit baithta hai:

“Wo jo pehli baar unka haath mere haath mein aaya tha,
Aisa laga jaise duniya ka sabse meetha sukoon mere hisse mein aaya tha.”
— Manhar Seth

“Ek hi haadsa toh hua hai yahan,
Unka haath hamare haath se chhoo gaya hai bas.”
— Jaun Elia

Ishq Ka Bukhar Aur Yaadon Ka Khazana

Use paani mein khelte, hasti hui, baalon se paani nichodti hui dekhte-dekhte poora din pankh laga kar ud gaya. Shaam hone ko aayi aur wapas lautne ka waqt ho gaya. Hum sab log thake hue par ek ajeeb si khushi ke sath wapas car mein baithe.

Lekin jaise hi main ghar pahuncha, mere jism ne ek alag hi khel dikhana shuru kiya. Uske bheege hue haathon ko chhoone ka nateeja ye hua ki us raat mujhe tez bukhar aa gaya! Wo bukhar kisi bimari ka nahi, balki us lams ke ehsaas aur us junoon ka bukhar tha. Bistar par lete-lete mera jism tap raha tha, par mere labon par ek bechain si meethi muskaan thi. Aankhein band karta toh bas uska bheega hua

chehra aur wo ride waala haath yaad aata.

Gulzar sahab aur Bashir Badr ki shayari mere zehen mein chalne lagi:

> *“Woh din jo tere sath guzare hain humne,*
> *Woh din meri umr ke sabse haseen safar the.”*
> *— Gulzar*
>
> *“Ujaale apni yaadon ke humare sath rehne do,*
> *Na jaane kis gali mein zindagi ki shaam ho jaye.”*
> *— Bashir Badr*

Agle Din Ki Coaching, Behen Ki Chhidai Aur Aage Ka Safar

Tez bukhar ke bawajood, agle din main coaching jaane se khud ko rok nahi paya. Aakhir wahan uski ek jhalak jo dekhni thi! Jism tap raha tha, par dil ki zidd ke aage bukhar ki kya aukaat?

Jab main agle din coaching ke corridor mein pahuncha, toh mere chehre par bukhar ki halki zardish ke sath-sath ek alag hi bechaini aur ek behad khoobsurat si muskurahat chamak rahi thi. Aisa lag raha tha jaise main kisi doosri hi duniya se laut kar aaya hoon.

Meri behen ne jaise hi mujhe dekha, wo apni seat se uth kar daudti hui mere paas aayi. Usne apna haath mere maathe par rakha aur ghabra kar boli— “Arey bhai! Tujhe toh sach mein tez bukhar hai… tu aaya kyo?”

Main bas halka sa muskuraya. Usne meri aankhon ki bechaini aur honthon ki us sharmili muskaan ko ek second mein taad liya. Phir kya tha, uske chehre par wo shaitani muskaan wapas aa gayi. Wo mere thode paas jhuki aur poori class ke saamne dheere se, par chhidate hue mere kaan mein uska naam le-le kar boli—

“Haye re mere bhai! Tujhe bukhar paani se nahi, uske bheoge hue haathon ko chhoone se chadha hai… Mubaarak ho, bhabhi ka jaadoo rang la raha hai!”

Wo poore din lectures ke beech-beech mein notebook par uska naam likh kar mujhe dikhati, kabhi peeche se phusphusakar uska naam leti, aur main sharma kar apna chehra kitabon ke peeche chhupa leta. Zakir Khan ki wo lines mere aur us behen ke is pyare rishte par bilkul fit baiththi thin:

> *“Arey hum toh mashhoor hi unke naam se hue hain,*
> *Ab koi unka naam leke chhidaye, toh bura thodi lagta hai… maza aata hai!”*
> *— Zakir Khan*

Hum dono har lecture ke gap mein bas water park ke us ek-ek pal ki baatein karte rahe—kaise wo tube slider par darr rahi thi, kaise car mein uski zulfen honthon par aa rahi thin, aur kaise raft ride par pehli baar humare haath mile the. Manhar Seth ke lafz mere dil mein goonj rahe the:

> *“Kuch baatein bolne ke liye lafzon ki zaroorat nahi hoti,*
> *Bas ek dost chahiye hota hai jo bina kahe sab samajh jaye.”*
> *— Manhar Seth*

Wo haseen yaadein humare dilon mein hamesha ke liye bas gayi thin. Us bukhar, us meethi bechaini aur behen ke us pyaare se mazaak ke beech humari Class 12 ki padhai dobara apni patri par aakar continue ho gayi. Padhai ke panno par ab Physics aur Chemistry ke formulas ke saath-saath uske haathon ka wo touch aur meri behen ki mithaas ghol chuki thi. Piyush Mishra sahab ki ye lines us daur ko bayaan karti hain:

> *“Wo din bhi kya din the jab ishq naya-naya tha,*
> *Har taraf bas unhi ka nasha chhaya tha.”*
> *— Piyush Mishra*

End of Chapter Five

CHAPTER SIX

Late-Night Chats, Reshmi Notes Aur Ant Ka Darr

Wapas Wahi Routine Par Ek Naye Rang Ke Saath

Water park ke us unforgettable trip aur ishq ke us bukhar ke baad, zindagi wapas apni purani patri par laut aayi thi. Subah ki wahi thand, coaching ka corridor, aur whiteboard par Physics-Chemistry ke derivatives. Lekin ab sab kuch pehle jaisa nahi tha. Mere andar ek naya ujala bhar chuka tha.

Ab subah uthte hi dimaag mein padhai ka nahi, balki uski ek jhalak pane ka nasha hota tha. Main coaching ke darwaze par waqt se pehle pahunch jata aur bas uske aane ka intezaar karta. Jab wo apni wahi peeli dress mein dakhil hoti, toh lagta jaise poore room mein roshni ho gayi ho.

Lata Mangeshkar aur Kishore Kumar ka wo evergreen gaana mere dil ki dhadkan ban kar bajne lagta:

> *“Aapki aankhon mein kuch mehke hue se raaz hain…*
> *Aapse bhi khoobsurat aapke andaaz hain.”*
> *— Lata Mangeshkar & Kishore Kumar*

Ab door se dekhne ka silsila badal chuka tha. Water park ke us lams ne humare beech ki jhijhak tod di thi. Ab hum Instagram par friends the, aur dhire-dhire humari baatein shuru ho chuki thin.

Instagram Ki Late-Night Chats Aur Screen Ki Roshni

Pehle jahan mera inbox mahino tak khali aur ‘Sent’ par atka rehta tha, ab wahan notifications ki ek meethi ghanti bajne lagi thi. Raat ke sannate mein, jab poora ghar so jata, tab mere phone ki screen par uska naam chamakta.

Wo late-night chats mere liye kisi khazane se kam nahi thin. Hum padhai ke baare mein, coaching ke teachers ke mazaak par, aur kabhi-kabhi aam zindagi par baatein karte. Jab screen par ‘Typing…’ likha aata, toh mera dil 100 ki speed se dhadakta tha.

Arijit Singh aur Shreya Ghoshal ke gaano ki mithaas mere kamre ki khamoshi mein ghulne lagti:

> *“Samajh mein aaye na tumhari baatein…*
> *Par sun’na achha lagta hai, tumhara bolna.”*
> *— Arijit Singh & Shreya Ghoshal*

Main uske bheje hue ek-ek word ko baar-baar padhta. Badal Sharma aur Rishabh Shukla ke alfaaz us daur par bilkul fit baithte hain:

> *“Wo jo raat ko der tak tumse baat hoti hai na,*
> *Bas wahi waqt meri din bhar ki thakan utar deta hai.”*
> *— Badal Sharma & Rishabh Shukla*

Uske Liye Notes Likhna Aur Woh Chhoti Khushi

Jab kisi se mohabbat hoti hai, toh uske kaam aana bhi ek alag hi sukoon deta hai. Jab bhi uski koi class miss hoti ya wo notes nahi bana pati, toh main aage hokar uske notes likhta.

Aapne kabhi kisi ke liye poori raat jaag kar hand-written notes banaye hain? Jab main uske liye apni sabse behtareen handwriting mein Physics ke formulas likhta, toh har ek pannel par mera pyaar chhap jata. Agle din jab main use wo

notebook thamata aur wo muskurakar kehti— “Thank you, Devanshu!”—toh lagta jaise poori duniya ki daulat mere haath lag gayi ho.

Sonu Nigam ki wo iconic aawaaz mere dimaag mein goonjti:

> *“Har ghadi badal rahi hai roop zindagi…*
> *Chhaav hai kabhi kabhi hai dhoop zindagi.”*
> *— Sonu Nigam*

Aur Manhar Seth ka wo andaaz mere dil se nikalta:

> *“Tere kehne par toh hum apni taqdeer badal dein…*
> *Ye toh bas kuch panno ke notes hain, hum toh poori kitaab tere naam likh dein.”*
> *— Manhar Seth*

Behen Ka Pyara Mazaak Aur “Dekh Bhai Kitni Sundar Lag Rahi Hai!”

Classroom ka mahaul ab behad khoobsurat aur shaitani ban chuka tha. Meri behen mere peeche wali bench par baithi hoti aur uske aage baithi hoti meri woh chahat.

Jab bhi woh ladki koi naya suit pehen kar aati ya apne baalon ko ek naye dhang se sawarti, meri behen aage jhukti, mere kaan mein chutki kaat-ti aur dheere se phusphusati— “Bhai… dekh toh sahi! Aaj toh teri bhabhi aasmaan se utri koi pari lag rahi hai! Dekh kitni sundar lag rahi hai wo!”

Main jab sharma kar gardan jhuka leta, toh meri behen thoda aur chhidate hue kehti— “Arey hero, sharma kyun raha hai? Seedhe dekh na, nazarein mat chura… tujhe hi toh dekh rahi hai wo!”

Zakir Khan ki ye lines mere dil ke jazbaat ko chhoo jaati thin:

> *“Arey hum toh mashhoor hi unke naam se hue hain,*
> *Ab koi unka naam leke chhidaye, toh bura thodi lagta hai… maza aata hai.”*
> *— Zakir Khan*

Aur Sunidhi Chauhan ka wo energetic romantic andaaz us mahaul par bilkul fit baithta tha:

> *“Uff teri ada, I like the way you move…*
> *Koi dekh le to ho jaye deewana.”*
> *— Sunidhi Chauhan*

Dheere-Dheere Aata Hua Class 12 Ka Ant Aur Ek Gehra Darr

Khushi jab apni charam seema par hoti hai, tabhi peeche se ek anjaane darr ki parchhai aane lagti hai. Calendar ke panno par tarikhein aage badh rahi thin aur Class 12 ke final exams paas aa rahe the. Aur uske saath hi paas aa raha tha—Coaching ka aakhiri daur.

Ek raat chatting karte-karte achanak mere dimag mein ye khayal aaya aur mera dil baith gaya. ‘Class 12 khatam hone ke baad kya hoga? Kya main use roz dekh paunga? Kya ye subah ki muskaan, ye zulfen, ye aankhein mere saamne hongi?’

Dr. Kumar Vishwas ki ye panktiyan mere andar ke sannate ko bayan karti hain:

> *“Kitni aasan hai mohabbat ki kahani likhna,*
> *Par behad mushkil hai unke bina aane wali zindagi jeena.”*
> *— Kumar Vishwas*

Aur Jaun Elia ka wo gehra dard mere zehen par chha gaya:

> *“Aane wala kal mujhe dara raha hai,*
> *Wo jo aaj mera hai, kya kal bhi mera rahega?”*
> *— Jaun Elia*

Har Pal Ko Precious Banane Ki Koshish

Us darr ne mujhe toda nahi, balki mujhe ek nayi samajh di. Maine tay kiya ki jitne bhi din baaki hain, main unhe rota hua nahi spent karunga. Main un aane wale har din, har pal ko itna khoobsurat bana dunga ki wo humare liye hamesha ke liye memorable ban jayein.

Ab jab bhi main coaching mein uske samne baithta, toh uski har ek smile ko apne dil mein lock kar leta. Uski aankhon ki wo masoomiyat, uske baat karne ka dhang, uske haathon ke ishare—main sab kuch apni yaadon ke album mein save kar raha tha.

Satinder Sartaaj ke Sufi geet mere andar gunjte:

> *“Saiyan saade dil nu tu sajjna sambhaal jee…*
> *Tere bin nahion jeena saday naal jee.”*
> *— Satinder Sartaaj*

Aur Gulzar sahab aur Bashir Badr ki lines mere har din ki dua ban gayi thin:

> *“Waqt ko thoda sa rok lo dosto,*
> *Uske saath bitaya har ek second meri zindagi ka sabse bada hissa hai.”*
> *— Gulzar & Bashir Badr*

End of Chapter Six

CHAPTER SEVEN

Kohre Ki Safed Chadar, Uphaar Aur Ehsaas Ka Wo Amar Din

Subah Ka Intezaar Aur Exams Ka Pressure

Class 12 ke final board exams ab sar par khade the. Calendar ke panno par tarikhon ki ginti jaise do-guna raftaar se aage badh rahi thi. Ek taraf physics ke derivations, chemistry ke reaction mechanisms aur maths ke lambe equations ka pressure thha, toh doosri taraf dosto ke saath roz ki wo behisaab shaitaniyan, coaching ke bahar ki chai aur halki-fulki taang-khichai. Sab kuch ek ajeeb se mix emotion ke saath chal raha tha.

Zindagi apni poori speed mein bhaag rahi thi, par dil kisi ek jagah par thaharna chahta tha. Mujhe kahan pata thha ki aane wala ek din meri zindagi ki sabse haseen yaadon mein humesha ke liye darj hone wala hai—ek aisa din jo saalon baad bhi jab yaad aayega, toh chehre par ek meethi si

muskaan aur aankhon mein ek halki si nami chhod jayega.

Uss din mausam mein ek alag hi thand aur ghaneri dhundh thi. Subah-subah kohre ki safed chaadar ne poore shahar aur raste ko apni aagosh mein sameta hua tha. Main hamesha ki tarah heavy jacket pehenkar, haathon ko jeb mein daal kar aalasi kadmo se coaching pahuncha. Subah ke lagbhag 7 baj rahe the, par thand ki wajah se sir thoda late the. Saare bachhe coaching ke bahar corridor mein ya road ke kinare ghoom rahe the. Main bhi bina kisi maqsad ke aage-peeche tahal raha tha.

Tabhi achanak mere peeche se ek soft lekin saaf awaz aayi:

“Bhaiya idhar aana… aapko koi bula raha hai.”

Maine mud kar dekha, wo awaz meri bahen ki thi. Par jaise hi maine uske peeche khadi uss ladki par nazar daali, mera dil ek second ke liye dhadakna bhool gaya. Main ek hi nazar mein samajh gaya ki aakhir mujhe sach mein kaun bula raha tha. Dil mein hazaaron sawalon ka sailab aur seene mein dhadkano ki tezz raftaar… main ek-ek kadam aise rakh raha tha jaise zameen par nahi, kisi khwab par chal raha hoon.

Maine jab un dono ki taraf kadam badhaye, tabhi bahen ne behad dheere se—jaise kisi ne kaano mein koi gehra, meetha sa raaz phusphusa diya ho—kaha:

“Bhaiya… aapki madam aapke liye kuch laayi hain.”

Wo shabd sunte hi jaise mere paanv tale se zameen nikal gayi! Dil mein ek anjaani si khushi ki lahar daud gayi aur saath hi ek aisi meethi ghabrahat jisse poore jism mein ek jhunjhuni si hone lagi. Main thoda aur paas gaya aur seedhe uske samne jaa khada hua.

Kohre Mein Chamakta Ek Chaand Aur Anjaan Nazrein

Uss thand aur kohre bhari subah mein bhi uska chehra aisi rangat, nikhhar aur roshni se damak raha thha, jaise kaali ghaneri amavasya ki raat ke beech poora chaand achanak baadlon ko faad kar chamak uthta hai. Uske galon par halki si gulabi rangat thi—shayad thand ki wajah se ya phir uss ghabrahat ki wajah se jo hum dono ke beech thhi.

Maine jab pehli baar uss pal uski aankhon mein seedhe dekha, toh laga main poori tarah hypnotize ho chuka hoon. Uss se pehle maine use kabhi is roop mein, itni masoomiyat, itne apnaaye aur itne haq ke saath apni taraf dekhte hue nahi dekha tha. Uski aankhon mein ek ajeeb sa noor tha jo shabd bayan nahi kar sakte.

Aaj ke shayar Badal Sharma ki ye lines mere mann ke sannate mein bilkul fit baith rahi thin:

> *“Tujhe dekhne ke baad kisi aur ko dekhna zaroori nahi lagta,*
> *Tujhe paane ke baad kisi aur ko maangna zaroori nahi lagta.*
> *Tere hone se hi mukammal hoti hai meri har ek subah,*
> *Tere bina toh mera chand bhi mujhe poora nahi lagta.”*
> *— Badal Sharma*

Hum dono bas ek-doosre ke samne khade the. Maine thoda hichkichate hue pucha, “Kya hua… sab theek toh hai?”

Usne halki si sharmili muskaan ke saath aasmaan ki taraf dekha aur phir meri aankhon mein aakhein daal kar behad dheemi awaz mein boli, “Ruko… itna bhi kya jaldi mein rehte ho hamesha?”

Wo alfaaz nahi the, jaise kisi ne sookhe seene par baarish ki pehli boond gira di ho. Dono taraf mukammal khamoshi thi, par wo khamoshi duniya ke kisi bhi lafz se zyada bol rahi thi. Corridors ke shor-shaba me bhi jaise ek alag hi shanti ka ehsaas ho raha tha—ek aisa lamha jo hum dono ke dil mein humesha ke liye qaid ho raha tha.

Wo Sparsh, Ek Chhota Sa Uphaar Aur Anmol Keemat

Tabhi usne apni jacket ki pocket se apna nazuk sa hath bahar nikaala aur meri taraf aage badhaya. Uske mehandi waale, chhote se hath mein ek keychain thhi.

Usne bina kuch bole, ek halki si jhijkte hue muskaan ke saath wo keychain meri taraf badhayi aur nazrein jhuka kar phusphusayi:

“Ye tumhare liye hai… sambhaal kar rakhna. Ye hamesha yaad dilayega ki koi hai jo tumhare har pal mein tumhare saath hai.”

Maine bina ek pal gavaye apna hath aage kar diya use lene ke liye. Maine bas itna hi kaha, “Ye sirf keychain nahi hai mere liye… meri saanson se bhi zyada keemti rahega ye.”

Jab main uske haathon se wo keychain pakad raha thha, tabhi un chand seconds ke liye mera hath uske hath ki ek ungli se chhoo gaya.

Sparsh… sirf ek ungli ka sparsh.

Par uss sparsh mein aisi thandak aur aisi ajeeb si shiddat thhi, jaise kisi ne tapte hue dil par barf ki kanchhi rakh di ho! Ek bijli si poore jism mein daud gayi. Thand ke mausam mein bhi wo sparsh dil ko ek alag hi garmahat de gaya.

Duniya ke liye shayad wo metal ya plastic ka ek mamooli sa keychain thha… koi bhi dukan se 20-50 rupaye mein khareed sakta thha. Lekin mere liye? Mere liye uski value duniya ke kisi bhi khazane se kahi zyada thhi! Kyunki wo sirf ek keychain nahi thha, wo uska pehla gift thha… uska pehla sparsh thha… uska pehla izhaar thha bina kuch bole.

Arijit Singh ke voice mein jo dard aur gehraai hoti hai, wahi ehsaas mere andar chal raha tha. Arijit ka mashhoor gaana “Shayad” (Love Aaj Kal) mere kaano mein gunj raha tha:

> *“Shayad kabhi na keh sakoon main tumko,*
> *Bina kahe samjh lo tum shayad…*
> *Jo tum na ho, toh hum bhi hum nahi,*
> *Na chahiye kuch tumse zyada, tumse kam nahi…”*
> *— Arijit Singh, “Shayad”*

Main mann hi mann khuda ka behad shukriya ada kar raha thha. Maine apne aap se kaha:

“Mujhe pata hai kal ko waqt aur halaat humein kahan le jayenge… hum saath honge ya nahi, zindagi humein kis mod par khada karegi… par ye keychain meri aakhiri saans tak mere saath rahegi. Ye mere paas uske hone ka sabse bada aur amar saboot ban chuki hai.”

Sir Ki Aahat, Class Aur Lautte Waqt Ka Ehsaas

Tabhi achanak corridor mein sir ke aane ki aahat hui. Sabhi bachhe jaldi-jaldi apni-apni benches par jaa kar baithne lage. Humari nazar ek doosre se hati. Uss aakhiri pal mein usne ek baar phir palat kar dekha, jaise bol rahi ho ‘Padhai par dhyan dena’.

Classes shuru hui, 2-3 ghante kaise beete pata hi nahi chala, aur lecture khatam hote hi sab apne-apne gharon ke liye nikal gaye. Lekin mere liye wo din koi aam din nahi thha. Laga jaise khuda ne zameen par hi mujhe swarg sounp diya ho. Laga ki main zindagi ki sabse badi baazi jeet gaya hoon.

Ghar lautte waqt jab main scooty chala raha tha, toh thandi hawa chehre par lag rahi thi, lekin dil ke andar ek aisi aag aur khushi thi jo mujhe bahar ki kisi thand ko mehsoos nahi hone de rahi thi. Mera ek hath pocket mein thha, jahan maine uss keychain ko tight pakad rakha thha.

Jubin Nautiyal ki aawaz mein jo ek raw emotion aur sukoon hota hai, wahi sukoon mere dil mein beh raha tha. Jubin ka gaana “Humnava Mere” mere dimaag mein chal raha tha:

“Tu aakhri aansu o yaara,
Tu pehli hasi hai meri…
Dil mein hawaon ki tarah,
Tu beh raha hai kahin.
Humnava mere, tu hi hai bas mera,
Tu hi dil ki pyaas hai…”
— Jubin Nautiyal, “Humnava Mere”

Aur Sonu Nigam ke uss iconic geet ki ye lines mere mann ki haalat ko perfectly describe kar rahi thin:

“Abhi mujh mein kahin, baaqi thodi si hai zindagi…
Kisi pehar aakar bane chaandni, tarasti hui iss zameen par.
Aise hi rimjhim baras jaaye ras ki phuhaarein,
Kahaani mein apni naya mod aaye…”
— Sonu Nigam

“Tera milna aisi ek dua ki tarah hai,
Jo bin maange hi mazaak-mazaak mein qabool ho jaati hai.
Zindagi mein log toh bohot milte hain,
Par koi ek hi hota hai jisse dekh kar saans thahar jaati hai.”

End of Chapter Seven

CHAPTER EIGHT

Kaali Saari, Woh Apsara Aur Nazro Ka Jaadoo

Jab Kainaat Ne Apni Sabse Haseen Takht-e-Husn Ko Mere Saamne Rakh Diya

Us shaam jab mai uske ghar se lauta tha, toh lag raha tha jaise mera jism toh mere kamre mein aa gaya hai, par meri rooh wahan uski dehleez par hi apna pata bhool aayi ho. Meri ungliyon ke beech ghoomta hua woh chhota sa keychain—mere kamre ki madhim, reshmi roshni mein chamak raha tha. Mai ghanton bas us par se aanch hataye bina use niharta rehta… Jaise us zara se metal ke tukde mein uski reshmi hansi, uski masoom, shararati baatein, aur uski saanshon ki mehakti hui khushbu hamesha ke liye qaid ho gayi ho. Din guzar rahe the, par har beetta hua din mere dil mein ek bechain si lehar todta tha. Coaching ke aakhri din paas aa rahe the aur uske school ka farewell sar par khada tha. Mujhe lagne laga tha ki jaise-jaise ye tareekhein mere kareeb aa rahi hain, mai khud apne aap se door hota jaa raha hoon. Dimaag mein bas ek hi shararat bhari, tadapati hui kasak chalti thi—'Ab mai apni us apsara ko kaise dekhunga? Uske bina ye sadkein, ye sehar, ye shaamein kitni veeran aur be-rang ho jayengi?'

Isi udhedbun mein din beet rahe the ki achanak uske school ke farewell ki final date ka pata chala. Khabar sunte hi dil ek pal ke liye thasak gaya. Dimag mein bas yahi socho ki bheed machi thi ki us din woh kis qadar saj-sanwar kar niklegi… Woh kitni mashoor-e-zamaana haseen lagegi… aur mai… mai use dekh bhi nahi paunga! Woh aakhri mauka

tha jab mai use jee bhar kar, bina kisi ruke apni aankhon mein basana chahta tha. Lekin kismat ko toh meri mohabbat ke aage jhukna hi tha. Isko khuda ki behadd barkat kahu ya mere dil ki woh shiddat bhari manifestation, farewell se theek ek raat pehle mera phone jagmaga utha. Screen par uska naam jagmagaya. Uska message aaya—"Kal mera farewell hai aur mujhe jaane ke liye car nahi mil rahi hai, kya tum meri help kar sakte ho?"

> *Maanga tha jo khuda se ek haseen lamha,*
> *Woh khud apna roop lekar mere paas aa gaya…*
> *Dil ne kaha ki aaj kainaat ruk gayi hai,*
> *Jab uska ek chhota sa paigham meri jaan le gaya!*

Usne toh sirf ek aam si help maangi thi, par mujhe laga jaise poori kainaat ne mere armanon par gulaab ke phool barsa diye hon! Man hi man mai us khuda ko hazaar baar shukriya bol raha tha ki usne mujhe ye din dekhna naseeb kiya. Bina ek microsecond soche, maine turant 'Haan' keh diya. Us raat meri aankhon se neend aise gaayab hui jaise subah hone par chaand gaayab hota hai. Saari raat mai bas bistar par karwatein badalta raha… Bas yahi sochta ki kal jab woh samne aayegi toh mausam ki kya haalat hogi? Woh kya pehnegi? Uska rang-o-roop kaisa kehar dhayega? Tabhi meri behen ne kamre mein aakar aag mein thoda aur ghee daal diya! Usne muskurate hue bataya ki woh kal do-do

sarees pehanne wali hai, aur shararat se aankh maarte hue boli, “Bhaiya, kal tu bhi chalna hum logo ke sath school drop karne!” Ye sunte hi aisa laga jaise usne mere dil ki sabse gehri khwahish padh li ho. Phir woh mere paas aayi aur bilkul kaan ke paas gungunayi, “Ab toh meri bhabhi bhi aa rahi hai!”

Agla din aaya. Bechaini itni zyaada thi ki aaj mai coaching jaane ki baat soch bhi nahi sakta tha. Ghadi ki suiyion par meri saanshein tiki hui thi. Jaise hi ghadi ne 11 bajaye, meri car bilkul saaf-sutri, chamchamaati hui taiyaar khadi thi. Mai gaadi ke paas khada bekaraar hokar intezaar kar hi raha tha ki… door se ek aakriti aati hui dikhi. Wahan se koi ladki nahi chal kar aa rahi thi, aisa laga jaise kudrat ne apni saari fursat, saara noor aur saari nazaakat ek jagah ikattha karke zameen par utaar diya ho! Usne kaale rang ki saree pehan rakhi thi. Us kaali saree par jade hue chaandi ke sitare aise jhilmila rahe the jaise amavasya ki kaali raat mein aasmaan ke tamaam taare ek sath zameen par utar aaye hon.

Agar chunari jhatak de toh tukde sitaron ke hazar karein mohini,
Zulfon ko agar khol de toh raat ko bhi aaftab karein mohini…
Woh kaali saree mein aisi aayi samne hamare,
Jaise chandni raat mein koi roshni ka gulaab khile mohini!

Mai toh bas shashdar khada rehta, bina palak jhapkaye use dekhta hi gaya. Uski woh reshmi, ghana dark kajal laga aankhein, woh kamar par lachakti hui kaali saree ka pallu, aur un honthon par halki si mithaas bhari muskaan… Aisa laga jaise duniya ki sabse khubsurat ladki mere saamne khadi hai aur baaki poori duniya dhundli ho chuki hai. Tabhi piche se behen ne mere kaan mein madhur si chhed-chaad karte hue koha, “Bhai… lag rahi hai na bilkul aapki wife… matlab meri pyaari bhabhi jaise?” Aur phir usne mujhe thoda aur uksate hue kaha, “Bhai, utar ke darwaja khol ke apne hathon se pakad ke bitha de na unhe!” Par afsoos! Meri himmat toh uske husn ke us be-inteha sailab ke aage wahi dher ho gayi thi. Dil chah raha tha ki uska haath pakad kar use gaadi mein bithaoon, par jism mein jaisey koi harchal hi na ho sake!

“Afreen afreen… Afreen afreen…
Aisa dekha nahi khoobsurat koi, jism jaise ajanta ki murat koi,
Jism jaise nigaahon pe jaadoo koi, jism jaise mehakta hua gundnooi…”
— Nusrat Fateh Ali Khan / Javed Akhtar

Gaadi chal padi. Mera dhyan sadak par kam aur car ke rear-view mirror par 100 guna zyada tha! Us chhote se aine mein uska woh jadooi, masoom chehra jagmaga raha tha. Maine turant dhire se driver ke kaan mein kaha, “Bhai… gaadi thodi dhiire chalana… aaram se.” Driver ne shatir muskaan ke sath gaadi ki speed kam kar di. Mai bas har ek second us aine mein uski aankhon ki chamak ko nigaahon se peeta raha. Uski har ek chhotisi ada par mera dil sau baar qurban hone ko taiyaar tha.

“Chaudhvin ka chand ho, ya aaftab ho…
Jo bhi ho tum khuda ki kasam, lajawab ho…”
— Mohammad Rafi / Shakeel Badayuni

Dhire-dhire sochte-sochte aur mirror mein use niharte-niharte uska school aa gaya. Humne use drop kiya aur wapas ghar aa gaye. Lekin mera dimaag ab bhi wahan uske school ke maidan mein hi bhatak raha tha. Kash mai bhi uske sath us farewell ke har ek lamhe mein shamil hota, kash

mai poora din uske aaspas rehkar uski reshmi baaton ko sun pata! Isi mehakte hue khayalon mein poora din beet gaya aur ab shaam hone ko aayi. Shaam ka woh magical ‘golden hour’ ka samay tha—aasmaan mein surkh, gulaabi roshni ghul rahi thi, aur hum use pickup karne ke liye school ke gate ke bahar khade the.

Tabhi school ka gate khula aur woh bahar nikli… Oh khuda! Suraj ki woh dhalati hui sone jaisi khubsurat kiran jaise hi uski saree ke taaron par aur uske gora-chitta, noorani chehre par padi, mere hosh-o-hawaas udd gaye! Aisa laga jaise chaand apni poori chaandni, apna poora roop lekar zameen par muskura raha ho. Uski khubsurati mein us waqt ek aisi roohani, behkaane wali chamak thi jise alfazon mein bayaan karna kisi bhi shayar ke bas ki baat nahi thi. Woh chal nahi rahi thi, jaise hawaon mein tair rahi ho!

> *Suraj ki dhalati kiran ne jab chhupke se unko chhua,*
> *Ek noor sa phaila har taraf, ek jadoo sa hua…*
> *Dekha jo unke chehre ko us golden hour ki roshni mein,*
> *Laga jaise chandni ne khud ko aine mein dekha hua!*
> *Kashish aisi ki nigaah hataye na hate unse,*
> *Kudrat ne bhi unhe banakar apna kalam tod diya…*

Dekhte hi dekhte hum uske ghar pahunch gaye. Par mere dil mein ek pyaara sa, romantic guilt hamesha ke liye reh gaya—kaash… kaash maine thodi si himmat dikhai hoti,

uska naram haath apne haath mein lekar use gaadi ke andar bitaya hota! Woh car se utari, ek behadd mithi aur qaatilana smile ke sath goodbye bolkar apne ghar ke andar chali gayi. Mai aur di baatein karte hue ghar wapas aa gaye. Lekin jaate-jaate behen ek baat phir se mere kaan mein phusphusayi, “Bhai… aaj kasam se bilkul meri BHABHI lag rahi thi!” Uski us nadani mein kahi hui baat ne mere dil mein romantic chingari lagaye rakhi thi, jo aaj tak bilkul tazah hai.

Ghar pahunchte hi meri behen ne apna asli ‘bhabhi-making’ kaam kiya! Usne farewell ki saari HD photos mere phone par bhej di, aur neeche ek chhotasa romantic caption likha—‘Meri Pyaari Bhabhi’. Bas phir kya tha! Ab mere din sirf uski khushbu aur khayalon mein beete aur raatein unhi behadd khubsurat, noorani photos ko ghanto zoom kar-kar ke dekhne mein… Khair, isi tarah dhire-dhire din nikalte gaye aur milne ke mauke kam hone lage, par us din ka woh kaala saree ka roop, shaam ki woh sunehri roshni, aur uski woh behkaane wali khubsurati mere dil ki har ek dhadkan par hamesha ke liye amar ho gayi!

End of Chapter Eight

CHAPTER NINE

Aakhri Din, Ek Na-Mukammal Khat Aur Intezaar Ki Sadiyan

Jab Waqt Ne Ek Sawaal Chhod Diya Aur Hawaon ne Unka Pata Dena Band Kar Diya

Coaching ke woh aakhri din… Kisi toofan se pehle ki shanti jaise the. Board exams sar par khade the, jinka intezaar shayad poori duniya mein koi nahi kar raha tha. Par mere liye exams ki tension se kahin zyada bada khauf ye tha ki ab har roz subah uski ek jhalak paane ka silsila khatam hone wala tha. Ab ye sadkein, ye coaching ki galiyan aur woh raste sunsaan hone wale the.

Isi khauf aur bechaini ke beech woh din bhi aa hi gaya—coaching ka aakhri din. Us subah jab mai so kar utha, toh dimaag mein padhai ya exams ka ek harf bhi nahi tha. Mere seene mein sirf ek hi zidd thi, ek hi tamanna thi—aaj bas use jee bhar ke dekhna hai, apni nigaahon mein hamesha ke liye basana hai, aur dil ki baat keh deni hai. Mai apne sath

ek lal gulaab chhupa kar le gaya tha. Woh gulaab sirf ek phool nahi tha, balki mere pichle kitne hi maahino ki khamosh mohabbat, meri ratjagi aur mere armanon ka nichor tha.

Lekin jaise hi woh mere saamne aayi… Meri saanshein wahi thamb gayin. Aisa laga jaise jism se aatma hi nikal gayi ho! Uske husn, uski masoomiyat aur uske noor ke aage mere tamaam alfaaz dher ho gaye. Woh gulaab mere pocket mein hi pada raha aur meri zabaan par jaise koi adrishya taala lag gaya. Har beetta hua minute mere dil par kisi aari ki tarah chal raha tha. Woh ek ghanta kaise beeta, mujhe pata hi nahi chala.

> *"Waqt ki shakh se lamhe nahi toda karte,*
> *Jo guzar jaye use peechhe nahi chhod aate…*
> *Humne toh bas ek jhalak mein poori zindagi maangi thi,*
> *Par kismat ke panne kabhi is tarah nahi juda karte."*

Aur phir… Woh waqt aa gaya jab sabko apne-apne raaste nikalna tha. Us pal aisa laga jaise kisi ne mere dil ko kisi purane kapde ki tarah pakad kar resha-resha karke faad diya ho. Ek ajeeb si tees, ek behadd gehri veerani mere andar bhar gayi. Woh chali gayi. Mai wahan khada raha, phir sir se aakhri baar thodi saazi formal baatein ki aur bhaare qadmon ke sath ghar ki taraf nikal pada.

Ghar aakar mera dimaag phatne ko ho raha tha. Ek taraf exams ka saaya tha, par mujhe na board ki tension thi, na result ki fikr. Mere andar bas ek hi guilt ka toofan uth raha tha—'Agar maine aaj usse nahi poocha, toh mai is bojh ke sath poori zindagi kaise rahunga? Woh toh ab chali gayi…'

Isi tadap mein maine apna phone nikala. Mere haath kaamp rahe the, par dil ke jazbaat rukne ka naam nahi le rahe the. Maine ek behadd lamba, rooh se likha hua proposal message type kiya. Us ek message mein maine apna poora dil khol kar rakh diya—har woh lamha, har woh nigaah, har woh bechain shaam jo maine uske naam ki thi. Message send ka button dabaya, phone ko side mein rakha aur aankhein moond kar bistar par pad gaya.

> *"Humne jo ki thi mohabbat, woh aaj bhi hai,*
> *Tujhe chhaahne ki ki thi jo shararat, woh aaj bhi hai…*
> *Likh diye tamaam alfaaz ek paigham mein,*
> *Tere ek jawaab ki guzaarish, woh aaj bhi hai."*

Shaam ko jab meri aankh khuli, toh maine sabse pehle kaampte haathon se phone uthaya. Screen par uska notification tha. Uski chat kholi… Aur wahan jo likha tha, usne mujhe ek aisi duniya mein phenk diya jahan se mai aaj tak bahar nahi nikal paya.

Usne likha tha: “Tumne agar sahi waqt par poocha hota toh shayad mai haan kar bhi sakti thi… Lekin abhi nahi. Agar kabhi man hoga toh bataungi.”

Woh alfaaz padhte hi mera dimaag sunn ho gaya. Ek aisa sannata chaa gaya jiske baad mai kuch soch hi nahi paya. Ek ‘kaash’ ka pahaad mere seene par aakar gir gaya. Kaash maine us din thodi himmat dikhai hoti… Kaash maine woh gulaab uske haath mein thama diya hota!

> *“Kuch toh majboori unki bhi rahi hogi,*
> *Warna koi yun hi bewafa nahi hota…*
> *Kashish toh bohot thi hamari chahat mein,*
> *Par har daastaan ka anjam mukammal nahi hota.”*
> *(Jaun Elia ke lafzon ki tarah—“Kitni ajeeb hai ye majboori-e-ulfat, hum unhe pa bhi nahi sakte aur khona bhi nahi chahte…”)*

Aaj saal 2026 ke maheene beet chuke hain… Woh din guze hue zamaana ho gaya. Par mai aaj bhi bas usi ek sawaal ka jawaab dhoond raha hoon. Maine apne dil aur man ko dhire-dhire samjhaana shuru kar diya hai, par jhooth kyun boloon? Aaj bhi dil ke kisi kone mein ek baariki si umeed ki kiran baaki hai… Ki shayad… Shayad kisi din, kisi mod par, uska koi jawaab aa jaye.

Khair, ab toh zindagi bas aise hi aage badh rahi hai. Na jaane aur kitne saalon tak is sawaal ke jawaab ka intezaar karna padega. Ye jawaab kabhi milega bhi ya nahi… Koi nahi jaanta.

> *"Laghzish-e-paa ka malal apni jagah,*
> *Uske raste mein khade hain abhi tak hum…"*

Lekin ek baat sach hai—ye meri zindagi ka sabse khoobsoorat aur sabse paak chapter tha, aur is chapter ka sabse khoobsoorat insaan… Woh thi. Woh aaj mere sath ho ya na ho, par uski yaadein, uski woh reshmi aankhein aur uski qaatilana smile hamesha mere paas rehti hain.

Ab toh haalat ye hai ki jab bhi koi thandi hawa ka jhonka mere paas se hokar guzarta hai, toh mera dil be-saakhta gunguna uthta hai—lagta hai ye hawa abhi-abhi uske jism aur uske baalon ko chhoo kar aayi hai…

> *"Tere bina zindagi se koi shikwa toh nahi,*
> *Tere bina zindagi bhi lekin zindagi toh nahi…"*
> *— Gulzar / Lata Mangeshkar*

Woh apsara shayad meri kismat ke panno mein aage nahi thi, par meri rooh ke har ek alfaz par sirf aur sirf usi ka naam likha rahega… Hamesha ke liye.

End of Chapter Nine

EPILOGUE

Dhalte Suraj Ki Aakhri Kiran Aur Ek Adhoora Intezaar

Khamosh Ashq, Behadd Shukriya Aur Hamesha Ke Liye Khula Rehne Wala Ek Darwaza

Special Thanks Message (Dil Ki Gehraiyon Se)

1. Meri Apsara Ke Naam (Woh Haseen Ehsaas Jo Kahani Ban Gaya)

“umhe meri zindagi ka sabse khoobsoorat, behadd roohani aur be-inteha shukriya…

Shukriya meri berang aur aam si duniya mein aakar un mehakti hui rangon ke phool khilane ke liye. Tumne mujhe kisi se bina kisi shart, bina kisi badle ki umeed ke shiddat se pyaar karna sikhaya. Tumhari woh ek muskaan, woh kaali

saree mein amavasya ke chaand jaisa chamakna, aur woh ‘golden hour’ ki dhalati sone jaisi roshni mein hawaon mein tairna… Ye sab sirf yaadein nahi hain, ye meri aatma par engraved wo naqsh hain jo mere aakhri saans tak nahi mitenge.

Mai khuda se bas itni hi dua karunga ki tum jahan bhi raho, jiske bhi naseeb mein raho, tumhare daaman mein duniya ki tamaam khushiyan, taare aur be-inteha muskurahatein hon. Chahe kismat ne hume ek na kiya ho, par tum mere dil ke sabse paak aur sabse haseen takht par hamesha ke liye virajman rahogi. Thank you for being the most beautiful memory of my life… Goodbye, my endless love.”

> *“Tu hi meri shab hai, tu hi meri subah hai…*
> *Tu hi meri duniya, tu hi meri dua hai.”*
> *— Pritam / Sayeed Quadri*

2. Meri Behen Ke Naam (Mera Sabse Sacha Sahara)

“Aur meri pyaari, nakhrebaaz behen… Tere liye toh ‘shukriya’ shabd bhi bohot chhota aur be-zaika lagta hai.

Tu agar mere sath na hoti, toh shayad ye adhoori daastaan bhi itni khoobsoorat na ban pati. Woh tera mujhe chhedna, woh kaan ke paas aakar ‘Bhabhi’ phusphusana, woh gaadi mein darwaza kholne ke liye uksana, aur raat ko photos bhej kar mere dil ko behlana… Tu sirf meri behen nahi, mere har ek khamosh dard ki sabse badi hamsafar aur meri is prem-kahani ki sabse khoobsoorat rooh thi.

Jab bhi mai apni bechainiyon mein ghira, jab bhi mera dil uske bina tadpa, tera woh shararat bhara muskurata chehra mere liye sabse bada sahara bana. Tu duniya ki sabse best behen hai. Tere is be-inteha pyaar aur sath ke bina meri zindagi aur ye kahani, dono hi adhure reh jaate.”

The Final Closing: Ek Sad, Long Aur Aakhri Umeed Se Bhara Alvida

Aaj ye kitaab yahan band ho rahi hai… Par mere seene mein sulagti hui woh aag, woh bechaini aur woh ek adhoora sawaal aaj bhi wahi khada hai.

Waqt aage badhta gaya, saal beet gaye, aur mausam badalte rahe. Sadkein wahi hain, coaching ki woh sunsaan galiyan wahi hain, par ab wahan woh aahat nahi hoti jiske liye mera dil har subah dhadakta tha. Zindagi ne mujhe chalkar aage badhna toh sikha diya, par mera ek hissa… Meri rooh ka ek tukda aaj bhi wahi coaching ke aakhri din ki

us shaam mein chhoot gaya hai.

Maine apne aap ko hazaar baar samjha liya hai ki ab shayad kabhi koi reply nahi aayega, ab kabhi phone ki screen par uska naam nahi jagmagaye-ga. Lekin dil toh aakhir dil hai na… Ye dimaag ki manta hi kahan hai? Aaj bhi jab 2026 ki shaam ko surkh gulaabi ‘golden hour’ ki roshni mere kamre ki khidki par padti hai, toh meri aankhein nam ho jaati hain. Aaj bhi jab koi thandi hawa mere chehre ko chhootey hue nikalti hai, toh mai apni aankhein band kar leta hoon… Is aash mein ki shayad is hawa mein uske baalon ki wohi purani khushbu ghuli ho.

> *“Dil dhoondta hai phir wahi fursat ke raat din,*
> *Baithe rahe tasawwur-e-jaanan kiye hue…”*
> *— Gulzar*

> *“Khabar-e-tahayyur-e-ishq sun, na junoon raha na pari rahi,*
> *Jo rahi so be-khabari rahi, na junoon raha na pari rahi…”*
> *— Siraj Aurangabadi*

Ek ajeeb sa dard bhara guilt mere seene par pahaad bankar baitha rehta hai—kaash… kaash maine us din thodi si himmat dikhai hoti! Kaash maine woh gulaab uske naram

haathon mein thama diya hota! Par ab un ‘kaash’ ke tukdon ko sametne wala koi nahi hai.

Mai nahi jaanta ki aage mujhe kitni sadiyon tak is sawaal ke jawaab ka intezaar karna padega. Mai nahi jaanta ki woh jawaab kabhi milega bhi ya mai is aakhri umeed ke sath hi ek din is duniya se khamoshi se rukhsat ho jaunga. Lekin mai aaj bhi… Haan, aaj bhi apne dil ka ek darwaza hamesha ke liye khula rakhunga. Ki shayad kisi din, zindagi ke kisi anjaane mod par, jab duniya thak jayegi… Tab shayad uski taraf se ek aahat aaye.

Tab tak ke liye, mai apni is ek-tarfa, paak aur behadd dard bhari mohabbat ko apne dil ke sabse gehre kone mein dafn karta hoon. Ye meri zindagi ka sabse sad, sabse emotional par sabse haseen chapter tha… Aur is chapter ki apsara hamesha meri rooh ke har ek lafz mein zinda rahegi.

“Hum toh thahr gaye unke intezaar mein aisi jagah,
Jahan se ab aage koi rasta nahi jata…
Woh mile ya na mile, par ye umeed toh rahegi,
Ki sachha pyaar kabhi zindagi mein fana nahi hota.”
— Nusrat Fateh Ali Khan ke bol ki tarah

Ek Aakhri Intezaar, Readers Ka Shukriya Aur Roohani Paigham

1. Readers Aur Buyers Ke Naam Ek Special Thanks Message

Aap sabhi readers aur buyers ka dil ki sabse gehri gehraiyon se behadd shukriya.

Aapne meri is daastaan ko sirf padha nahi, balki mere har ek ehsaas, mere har ek dard, aur meri mohabbat ke har ek lamhe ko apna banakar mehsoos kiya hai. Ek writer ke liye uske alfaaz tabhi zinda hote hain jab koi unhe apne dil se lagaye. Aap sab ke is be-inteha pyaar aur sath ke bina meri ye kitaab, ye safar, aur ye jazbaat bilkul adhoore the.

> *“Alfaaz toh bohot the mere paas kehne ko,*
> *Par aapne sunkar unhe daastaan bana diya…*
> *Dil ke har ek panne par likhi thi jo veerani,*
> *Aapke pyaar ne use ek khoobsoorat jahan bana diya.”*

2. A Special Note For Her (Ayushi): Ek Pukaar Aur Zindagi Ka Sabse Bada Waada

Suno Ayushi…

Aapko ab bhi azaad rakhta hoon apne har intezaar se, par dil ke kisi kone mein ek aakhri shart aur ek aakhri umeed

hamesha zinda rahegi.

Zindagi ke kisi bhi mod par, chahe kitne bhi saal beet jayein, jab bhi tumhara man kare… Bas ek baar, sirf ek baar phone uthana aur ek chhotasa message type kar dena—"Ab haan hai."

Us ek message ke baad ye duniya dekhegi ki tumhari us ek 'HAAN' ki keemat kya hoti hai! Yeh duniya dekhegi ki jab ek ek-tarfa chahat ko uski manzil milti hai, toh kismat aur aasmaan kaise jhukte hain. Woh ek 'haan' meri poori duniya ko haseen bana dega, aur mai tumhari zulfon ke saaye mein apni poori zindagi qurban kar dunga.

> *"Tera ek ishaara ho toh mai kismat ki laqeerein badal doon,*
> *Tu haan toh keh ek baar… mai zamane ke tamaam taare tere daaman mein dhar doon."*

3. A Special Thanks From My Side (Devanshu) To Her & Di

To Ayushi:

"Ayushi, tum mera woh khwaab ho jise mai har raat apni band aankhon se niharta hoon. Meri zindagi ke is sabse khoobsoorat chapter ka roop banne ke liye aur mujhe be-inteha pyaar ki taaqat sikhaane ke liye… Thank you so

much, Ayushi. Tum mere dil ki rani thi, ho, aur hamesha rahogi."

To Di (Anushka):

"Anushka Di… aap sirf meri badi behen nahi, meri sabse badi strength aur meri is daastaan ki sabse pyari rooh ho. Jab mai khamosh tha, tab aapne meri dil ki baat padhi; jab mai sharmaya, tab aapne mujhe aage badhaya. Woh aapka mujhe 'Bhabhi' kehkar chhedna aur meri har bechaini mein mere sath khade rehna… is sab ke liye mera poora wajood aapka shukraguzar hai. Thank you so much for everything, Anushka Di!"

A Final Farewell to All Readers and Buyers

To every single reader and buyer, I extend my deepest and most heartfelt gratitude.

Thank you for giving your valuable time, turning these pages, and bestowing so much love upon this book. For any writer, your constant support and appreciation are the greatest rewards imaginable. This journey would never have been possible without each and every one of you. Wishing you all the very best, and a most sincere Thank You and farewell from the bottom of my heart!

The End

About the Author

Devanshu Awasthi is a first-time author who writes the way he loves—quietly, patiently, and without expecting anything in return. *Until 28 October* began as a handful of late-night notes about a coaching-class corridor and a girl in a yellow dress, and slowly grew into a full account of what it means to love someone fully without ever fully saying so.

He lives somewhere between exam syllabi and unfinished poems, and still believes some doors are worth leaving open—even the ones that may never open again.

This is his first book.

If this story stayed with you, consider leaving it a review wherever you read it—it's the easiest way to help a quiet love story like this one find its next reader.

Thank you for reading.

FICTION / CONTEMPORARY ROMANCE

Coaching ki ek class, ek pehli nazar, aur ek mohabbat jo kabhi poori tarah kahi hi nahi gayi. Ek ladke ki dastaan jo saalon tak khamosh rehkar bhi utni hi shiddat se jeeta raha, jitni koi apni sabse bulandi wali mohabbat mein jeeta hai—ek dil jo door se dekhta raha, likhta raha, aur aakhir mein sabse mushkil kaam kiya: peeche hatna, bina pyaar ko kam kiye.

“Woh apsara shayad meri kismat ke panno mein aage nahi thi, par meri rooh ke har ek alfaz par sirf aur sirf usi ka naam likha rahega… Hamesha ke liye.”

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Devanshu Awasthi writes quiet, heartfelt stories drawn from real moments—a coaching-class corridor, a borrowed keychain, a message that waited months for a reply. *Until 28 October* is his first book: an honest account of loving someone fully while slowly learning to let go. He still believes some doors are worth leaving open.

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A TRUE-TO-HEART MEMOIR — DEVANSHU AWASTHI